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HOW TO READ ANYONE'S MIND

A BRIEF WORD OF INTRODUCTION
FROM THE AUTHOR

Here's everything I've used to obtain information and cooperation from others, to sell, negotiate, influence, persuade, motivate, coach and counsel. The most valuable thing we do is to make relationships work, professional and personal, and so these Strategies have, in my mind, immense value. Even with all this, I certainly do not succeed every time and I suppose no one does. However, I've found these Strategies of great value and hope that you will too.

To internalize and be able to use many of these, you will have to begin with very conscious effort and practice. Given time and repetitive use, they'll become "second nature" to you.

Best,

Dan S. Kennedy

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SUBVERT YOUR OWN EGO

Boy, are we vain! And, at the drop of a nickel, we'll be into the "can you top this game" with anybody we're talking with. If the other person has an "I was so drunk" story, we've got a better one - if the other person has a sexual conquest story involving twins, we've got to trot out ours, involving triplets. And, when we legitimately know more about something than the other person, we are compelled to demonstrate that superior knowledge.

This tendency must be suppressed if you are intent on learning as much as possible about a person from a particular conversation.

The Ego is the enemy of communication anyway. The perfect path to another's trust is the suppression of your ego, so that his may shine.

THE EASIEST WAY TO GET ANYBODY TO CONFIDE IN YOU LIKE THEIR MOST TRUSTED FRIEND, FAST

There is a classic persuasive/marketing principle: people want most what they get the least of. And what most people get the least of is recognition, appreciation. This is true of the most successful person you know as it is of the most 'ordinary' person you know. At all levels of achievement, people are starved for recognition and appreciation. You can open a person up like magic, by dispensing lots of these two things.

For example, the busiest person in the world will back off from his busyness, will have all his calls held, will drop whatever he's doing to spend time with you and tell you everything you can think of asking -- if you're very, very appreciative of how busy and important he is, of the time he makes for you.

When a person gives you some information, if you demonstrate appreciation for it and recognition of its value, guess what? He'll be eager to give more. I get a lot of free consulting and help from otherwise high-priced, busy experts with this strategy. I'll say something like: "You know, just that piece of information, that story's worth the price of lunch. I'm going to be able to use that...." and I'll describe the value the information has for me. What does this prompt? More disclosure. With this approach, I can get CEO's telling me their life stories and disclosing all the details of their businesses and finances in very short order.

Keep in mind that everybody loves giving advice. Asking people for their opinions and their advice is a certain way to open a person up and get him "spilling" what he knows.

HOW TO ASK QUESTIONS

1. Ask questions that cannot be answered 'yes' or 'no.'

2. Preface with "What do you think about..." or "how do you feel about...."

3. Form an extension question by repeating key words.

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Example:
Wife: "You seem pre-occupied. Is anything wrong?"
Husband: "No."
Wife: "There must be something."
Husband: "Just a little trouble with the boss."
Wife: "Trouble with the boss?"

4. Start with questions that are easy to answer.

5. Exchange information - don't relentlessly interrogate.

6. Stimulate further disclosure by agreeing when you can.

STUDY GOOD INTERVIEWERS

Here's your opportunity to watch television with a purpose. Many talk show hosts are very skilled interviewers, adept at getting their guests to "reveal themselves." Barbara Walters, Dick Cavett, Johnny Carson, Larry King and Oprah Winfrey are exceptionally talented interviewers.

When you watch these and other hosts/interviewers, take note of the things they do repetitively and consistently. Look for the skill behind the style, the thing that is done so consistently it must be "principle."

DETERMINE THAT YOU WILL LEARN SOMETHING FROM EVERYBODY

This is an attitude that is particularly useful in getting information from others - a firm conviction that there is something to be learned from everyone and a determination to learn something from everyone.

As with most things, attitude is at least as important as aptitude, if not more important. This simple mindset will draw people to you and motivate them to open up to you.

LISTENING SKILLS

You probably know: the inability to listen accurately and effectively costs this country billions and billions of dollars annually. There are big problems: defense contractor costs overruns, airplane crashes, all sorts of mistakes made in business and industry, because while one person insists he said it right, it was heard wrong. There are little productivity problems, too. And business and personal relationship destruction. And students' poor grades. And on and on - all because, while enormous investments are made throughout childhood and adult life to teach us how to speak and how to write, very little is done to teach us how to listen.

I read a very interesting article years ago, where a number of professional prostitutes were interviewed, and many said that many of their "regulars" often paid not for sex; didn't even have sex; but for someone to listen to them. Just recently, I saw a "Geraldo" show with operators of

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900-number/800-number "phone sex" businesses, and they said the same thing - many regulars call and do not engage in explicit sex talk but instead talk about the day they had, their frustrations at work or at home, etc. - they pay for someone who will listen to them. This is just one of many situations that has convinced me that REAL listening is a rarity, and therefore immensely valuable and marketable.

To listen effectively and ACTIVELY, I think you need to do all these things:

L = *Like*...you have to find some thing(s) to honestly like about the other person.

I - *Interest...*you have to instantly cultivate a sincere interest, either in the other person or in the content of what the other person is saying. For example, I'll pay attention to, say, Crandall, the CEO of American Airlines because of an interest in what he's saying on a talk show, because I travel a lot, and because I'm in business, not because he is a particularly interesting person; I'll pay attention to what Gregory Hines is saying on a talk show, not because I'm interested in tap dancing, but because he is an interesting, passionate person.

S = *See.*..meaning you have to really extend yourself to see the other person's point of view, to visualize the background and causes of the person's thinking...to use your mind's eye for greater understanding.

T = *Touch.*..meaning you have to let yourself be 'touched' and, as the phone company says, "reach out and touch" the other person; let there be emotional linkage. If you try to keep yourself distant and uninvolved, the other person will sense it, respond by mirroring, and crawl into a protective shell.

E = *Engage.*..take some initiative and be actively involved, without taking away control from the other person. Display your involvement by nodding, posture, other body language, brief questions, agreement when possible, non-offensive devil's advocate type questions when you do not agree.

N = *Need...*you've probably heard the phrase "need to know," as in - "we'll tell them on a 'need to know' basis"...I suggest operating on a NEED to know basis; you have such a thriving, thirsty curiosity about what makes people tick that you really need to know as much about other people as you need to breathe. This creates clearly sincere enthusiasm for what others tell you, encouraging them to tell you more.

ACTIVE LISTENING means that, overall, you are as involved in a conversation as the person doing most of the talking. Leaning forward, nodding, appropriate facial expressions, in business setting, taking notes all help. The most important part of all, though, is 'total concentration.'

To be able to totally concentrate, you have to first do what 'Psycho-Cybernetics' author called "clearing the calculator." Most little hand-held calculators have to be "cleared" of one problem before working on another. You have to do this mentally. You may use meditation, self-hypnosis, the Silva Method, whatever. But there is nothing more flattering or compelling than totally concentrating on another person's personality.

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THE TECHNIQUE OF "DISPLAYED INTEREST"

Every one of us has, at least once, had the experience of meeting and spending time with someone who displayed such rapt fascination with us that we wound up telling them the most amazing things about ourselves...we so enjoyed being with them we sought to prolong the meeting. Many times, this is courtship behavior. We fall in love with the person of the opposite sex who seems to be unendingly fascinated with us!

I was reminded of this not long ago, when meeting with the owner of a public relations firm that I was considering hiring. She was fascinated with me. She was so focused on me a bomb could have gone off without disturbing her concentration. I was completely captivated by her non-verbal flattery. It was only after the meeting that I logically analyzed what had just happened, how I'd been mesmerized, how I'd wound up talking so much about me.

It's this kind of Displayed Interest that can get people to tell you everything about themselves.

I WILL NEVER FORGET....

....a young lady I knew only as a business acquaintance whipping out one of her newly remodeled breasts for my inspection. What could provoke such behavior? In thinking it over afterward, I'm convinced it was nothing more (or less) than my being an extraordinarily good listener, to a person desperate for attention and consideration. It is only one of many, I think amazing incidents that have happened to me while practicing the art and science of listening.

Most people go through their daily lives with others only "surface listening" to them. I experience this constantly myself and so do you. People ask us how things are going or how we are without wanting to know or waiting to hear anything more than a "Fine" or "okay." Most people 'listen' while doing other things - walking, shuffling paper, whatever. At home, dinner conversation is replaced by the TV trays in front of the tube, and I'm guilty of it too. After a period of time of this, a person becomes remarkably vulnerable to anybody who stops, digs in and really listens. A great cause of unhappiness in many peoples' lives is the absence of anyone who is thoroughly fascinated with them and what they're all about. Filling this void gives you access, even control.

WHAT DOES 'READING BETWEEN THE LINES' REALLY MEAN?

You've heard the phrase - "you have to read between the lines" - but what does that really mean? When a person talks or writes, he communicates two ways at the same time; with EXPLICIT messages and IMPLICIT messages. Explicit is the actual, as-stated message. Implicit is the "extra message" implied by voice inflection, body language, punctuation, etc.

Just as an example, has someone ever said to you, "If I were you, I would..." Or, has someone said, "I don't care where we go for lunch. Chinese'd be great, but I'm up for anything." In both cases, there is an implicit or extra message quite different from the explicit message. And, in both cases, there is an attempt at manipulative control. In the first example, the person really means: here's what to do. In the second, the person really wants Chinese.

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Discipline yourself to ALWAYS listen for the implicit or extra message.

Incidentally, the less secure a person is, in general or in a particular situation, the more likely he'll communicate his true thoughts through these extra messages rather than his exact words.

EYE CONTACT

At conventions or trade shows I sometimes catch myself committing this "communication sin" - carrying on a conversation with one person while frequently glancing around, watching for other people I know and need to talk to. Maybe it's forgivable in the trade show environment, but it's still discourteous to the other person and, more importantly, a huge impediment to total communication.

Maintaining total, unwavering eye contact with the other person gives you incredible power. This is another aspect of active listening, of displayed interest, of flattery, all of which contributes to the other person's desire to confide in you. Also, because "the eyes are the windows to the soul," you gain an intuitive sense of the other person via the eye contact.

BODY LANGUAGE

You probably remember "body language" as kind of a business fad. For a while, everybody was writing about body language, everybody was talking about body language. It was "hot." Then the business public moved its attention to the next panacea and it was pretty much forgotten. If you find a book on body language at the bookstore today, it'll be buried on a bottom shelf with dust on it. However, it's as valid as ever.

We communicate much more openly nonverbally than we do verbally. Even while our lips lie, our physical movements tell the truth. (Some people have a real problem with their facial expressions and other physical movement matching what they're saying so that, while others may not realize it consciously, it makes them uncomfortable subconsciously, so that they do not trust that person.)

There are two ways to use an understanding of body language. One is in the reading of others' minds. How do you tell when the person across the desk has "bought" your idea? If there are ten women at a bar, how do you tell which one is eager to be asked to dance? If you're a speaker, and there are twenty people in the front row, how can you tell which one is best to pick on and kid around with - and which one to leave alone? In an office setting, how can you determine when someone is really "in a good mood," to approach them with your idea or request?

The second use of an understanding of body language is in reinforcing and empowering your own verbal communication. You can first make sure that your physical movements and facial expressions are congruent with what you're saying and how you're saying it. You can go beyond that and make your physicality communicate on a level by itself. There are masters at this. If you watch the Personal Power/Tony Robbins TV infomercial with the sound turned off, you'll still pick up a certain positive, intriguing energy from Tony throughout the show, but if you watch many other people being interviewed, regrettably, myself included, that doesn't shine through.

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Glen Turner has a particular body movement he makes during the course of a motivational speech, hooked to an especially compelling and persuasive point, that draws the audience's attention, pulls them toward him, actually moves them to the edges of their seats.

In one-on-one selling, I've learned there's a physical "way" that communicates neediness to the other person, and drives away sales. There's a different physical "way" that communicates complete dispassion about whether or not the sale gets made, that draws sales in. For want of a better way to describe it, the relaxed body language wins every time.

In Johnny Carson's closing broadcast, he brought a stool out on stage and sat down on the stool, to talk to the studio audience and viewers at home - I think the first time he had ever sat down on a stool on stage. Why did he do that? By doing that he instantly and more effectively communicated: "Tonight is very different and very special, and I'm going to deal with it and you differently, more intimately than ever before. I'm not going to talk at you; I'm going to share with you" than if he had said all that a hundred times over.

If you want to end a conversation, you can hasten the other person along with certain body language. If you don't mind annoying the other person, looking at your watch is the blatant version of this.

We can convey what's on our minds and discover what's on others' minds with body language, and I suggest blowing the dust off the old body language books and making a fresh study of all this to be a very useful thing to do.

MIRRORING

Tony Robbins has "popularized" this, but it's not anything new. The Amazing Kreskin, a mind-reader by profession, wrote this, back in 1984:

"The ideal rapport is a mirror image of those you're confronting. Let them see their best selves in you. If you're talking to someone who's bombastic, be pleasantly bombastic, but not competitive. If the person is shy and soft-spoken, reflect that tone in yourself...there's a little of everyone else inside each of us, and the challenge is to find what in us is in tune with the other person and reflect it.

Each of us has a particular way of speaking, a cadence, a speed, a vocabulary. Most of us appreciate a particular kind of humor - we don't necessarily laugh at the same jokes that our neighbor does. Being in tune means reflecting these aspects of the other person.

Even your physical presence can enhance or detract from rapport. I'm quick to remove the tie and jacket and roll up shirt sleeves the instant I sense my audience is in a casual mood....
I study the person's gestures. Does he use his hands a lot? I do too. If not, then I won't either."

Simply, people accept, trust and spill their guts to people who they see themselves in. I've often done very well with hugely successful, entrepreneurial men who created their success out of dust, struggled, failed, recovered, made it through hard work and hustle - because they see themselves in me. Conversely, I have a rough time dealing with corporate, middle management bureaucrats

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who've gone from college to corporate environment, and are better at office politics than anything else - because they cannot see any of them reflected in me. But, when you really understand this, you can identify some 'thing' about just about everybody you can mirror.

Humor, mentioned by Kreskin, is a great mirroring opportunity. Recently, I was the odd man out, the new dynamic in a group of fine people who had already been working together, been at several meetings together, and, although they were not in sync themselves, their corporate political tendency would be and was to unite in fear and resistance against the "outsider." As I sat there that morning, hoping for an opportunity to create rapport with somebody, the fifth guy rolled into the meeting room and told everybody a joke. In this case, it was a macho, coarse, "blue" joke, a locker room joke. This told me a lot about that guy. Among other things, I decided to be a little "earthy" in my language, particularly when agreeing with or piggybacking on this guy's comments. It wasn't long before he "bought me," became my ally, nodded approvingly when I made a point.

I'll tell you something very interesting about all this, hopefully in a way that is not offensive to anybody. I have a number of friends in the hair styling/hair salon industry, including a lady I've been friends with for many years - in fact, we dated between my marriages. Most of the men in her salon and, in my observation, in the industry, are openly gay. Women love these guys. They attach themselves to them, they confide in them, they tell them the most amazing things. We've talked about this, and everyone concludes that the reason is mirroring; these gay men mirror the women.

There's a fine line here, to be aware of. I do not suggest becoming a total chameleon, changing to match the other person like a chameleon changes colors to match his environment. That's going too far. You have to be you; there has to be a core personality that is a constant. But short of cutting into that core personality, you can learn to modify your approach, to "lean" in the same direction as the other person you're working with at the moment.

The example of speed of speaking is a good one. Slowing or accelerating your speed of speaking is certainly not the same as compromising your personality. But it can be very helpful in making the other person comfortable. When you meet a new person for the first time, that person instantly provides a "snapshot" of what they're comfortable with - their speed of speaking, their posture, their gestures - and you can immediately make some modifications in yourself, to mirror the other fellow. I think of it as about a 20% adjustment; 80% of me stays constant, 20% tries to adapt, to mirror the other person I'm dealing with.

THE RIGHT IMAGE

Your "outer package" does have an impact on how quickly and easily people accept you, trust you, relax with you, and reveal themselves to you. I can tell you for a fact, for example, that chiropractors who meet with new patients dressed "like a doctor" will get farther, faster, than the chiropractor who insists on being "casual." There are occupational biases, geographic biases, all sorts of biases, and you can use them to your advantage or fight them, your choice.

A very successful consultant and friend of mine, Nido Qubein, well, the joke about Nido at National Speakers Association conventions is - "You'll find Nido in the pool - easy to spot - only

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guy in there in a three-piece pin-striped suit." Nido deals almost exclusively with Fortune 1000 clients and he has identified that those people will be most comfortable with him if he looks, in every way, like one of them, even a slightly superior version of them. In his case, he's both 'mirroring' and meeting their expectations; in the doctor's case, he's meeting expectations.

There are, of course, exceptions, contradictions - you can have great influence by appearing totally contrary to expectations. I'd imagine Gary Halbert has that occur. I know Dick Sutphen has it happen. But you have to be "set up" very, very well for this to work.

The safer, surer approach is to meet expectations, when appropriate, mirror.

BE PREPARED

I'm amazed at the people who go into sales calls, negotiations, meetings, etc. wholly unprepared, either 'winging it' or applying the same 'canned' procedure to everybody. This is fine if you're selling a nickel-and-dime commodity, but if you're dealing in the 'Important,' it's best to be as prepared as possible.

A lot of the people I deal with have books they've written or that have been written about them, tapes, there have been magazine or newspaper articles, or I know somebody who knows them - and, before a meeting, I'll delve into as much of this as I can to get a 'feel' for that person. For my high-priced seminars, I have attendees complete and turn in detailed questionnaires in advance, so I can get that 'feel' for them before actually meeting them. From this kind of information, I'm often able to correctly anticipate how a particular person thinks, how they're 'wired.'

OBSERVE

I like meeting with people in their environments, because their environments reveal a lot about them.

An office with a wall full of plaques and certificates versus one with a wall full of photographs of people, one says something very different than the other, doesn't it? I deal with several ex-pro athletes. One has an office virtually devoid of memorabilia from his sports career. Another has an office full of footballs, trophies, photographs of teammates, and so on. What do these two offices communicate? I initially gambled and was proved right that the first person's office says that he has decided to put all that behind him; in fact, he is eager to shed his jock past and be known for his entrepreneurial accomplishments. Talking sports with this guy is a mistake. Ignoring that entirely and zeroing in on business discussion is correct. The second fellow still clings to and relies on his on-field accomplishments and that celebrity. He is comfortable with that, still uncomfortable with the business world. Asking him for an autographed ball is the right thing to do.

There's a scene in the movie 'Shining Through' where Michael Douglas asks Melanie Griffith to close her eyes and recall what she has noticed about his office. It's a good test. When you go into a new environment, challenge yourself to be so observant that you can close your eyes after a

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minute and recall a lot of detail about the office. Then analyze what that office has to say about its occupant.

THE CHINK IN THE ARMOR

Everybody, no matter how successful, has at least one 'chink in the armor' and knowing about it may help you better deal with that person. Often, in fact, more often than not, it's a self-esteem related chink.

For example, I have one client and friend, a very, very successful, smart, capable businesswoman, in the top 5% income bracket in the U.S., probably in the top 5% in her particular profession, and, on the surface, understandably very confident and independent. But she is remarkably "hung up" on the fact that she did not attend college. Her feelings about this "lack" inhibit her and affect her in surprising ways. There's another individual I deal with, again, in his profession, enormously successful, but largely disliked by his peers, not respected by his staff, and totally taken for granted by his spouse. This guy is starved for recognition. I have a client who has gone through years of struggle, then several years of remarkable success; he is terrified that it's going to end tomorrow. Can you see how being aware of the chinks in these peoples' armor makes it easier to help them, if you're into helping them; to sell to them; to manipulate them? To predict how they will respond to a particular idea or situation?

FIVE HUMAN CHARACTERISTICS THAT CAN BE RELIED ON; WHAT ARE PEOPLE THINKING

1. Resistance To Change: Yes, people can be motivated to accept, even welcome change, but, initially, the instant reaction to any and all proposed or perceived change is resistance, for a variety of reasons, including fear, inconvenience, laziness, territorial protectiveness, etc.

2. Wandering Attention: People have limited and decreasing attention spans. They lack the ability and know-how to concentrate. Their attention can easily be attracted by anything that is pleasurable, exciting or entertaining. The more complex the idea you are presenting, the more certain 'wandering attention' is. Therefore, at any given moment, you can bet the other person is thinking about personal concerns, his 'to-do' list, a sexual fantasy, just about anything but the subject at hand.

3. Wishful Listening: People have the uncanny ability to hear what they want to hear, not what is being said. And they'll later swear they heard what they believe they heard.

4. Jumped-To Conclusions: People are impatient, so, rather than hearing another person out, they'll often mentally cut him off and make an assumption about everything he's saying.

5. Habitual Negative Thinking: Most people think mostly negative thoughts. Their first reaction will be to see the negative, the difficult, the impossible and the unpleasant aspects of something.

When you keep in mind that these five characteristics largely control the way a person is thinking most of the time, it becomes ridiculously easy to "predict" their specific thoughts and reactions in

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a particular situation. If using this for persuasive purposes, you then want to prepare with all this in mind and try to control these elements rather than letting them control the outcome.

HOW PHYSICAL CHARACTERISTICS AFFECT PERSON'S THINKING

It's my belief that short men are more aggressive, meaner, if in power, more bullyish than tall men. Overweight men are more easily intimated and more motivated by a desire for acceptance, recognition and respect than men of average weight. Blonde, very attractive women are most eager to demonstrate their intellect, to be asked for their opinions on important matters. Women are much more observant than men, so a man's dress and appearance is more important when meeting with a woman than when meeting with a man. A woman wearing a lot of jewelry is easily influenced by flattery; a woman wearing little or no jewelry will be turned off by casual flattery.

All this is stored in my memory bank. I don't think about it much, consciously; in fact, I had to work at dragging it out for this report, but it is there and it does influence my behavior with these types of people.

What observations have you made about how physical characteristics are predictive of thinking and behavior?

Sure, these are generalizations, biases. And I know that they are subject to attack as over-simplifications, and certainly subject to exception. But I ask that you keep in mind that I deal, in one-on-one situations, with dozens of different people each week, a thousand or so a year, and, in groups, tens of thousands more, and I believe I have sufficient evidence to draw and reasonably rely on these conclusions. And when you consider the pace most of us are on these days, the speed at which we meet, greet, interact with, and move on, the use of pigeonholing, of quickly categorizing people is virtually essential.

DEMOGRAPHIC CLUES TO ATTITUDES

People born and raised in the midwest are more trusting and trustworthy than those raised in California. How do you feel about that statement? Sure, it's unfair. There certainly are very trustworthy people born, raised and living in California. I have one or two such clients there myself who have the highest imaginable integrity. and certainly there are some people of zero integrity born and raised in Kansas, Indiana and Ohio. But, setting aside the individual cases and deliberately trying to develop a generalization that is truer than false, I'd bet on this one.

Let's stay with California for a second. Image and appearance is more important there than anywhere else in the United States. People in L.A. are much more likely to quickly form very firm conclusions about you based on the car you drive, clothes you wear, and whether or not you have a portable phone than people in, say, New Orleans or Indianapolis. If you're going to do business in L.A., you'd better get a grip on this.

People raised in high income families will have very different values and opinions than people raised in low income families. People living in major metropolitan cities respond differently than

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those living in small towns, to just about everything. For example, there's less cynicism in small town residents than in city dwellers. People with children - parents - certainly respond differently than do married couples who do not have children.

In marketing to groups of people, we consider their demographic commonalities. When we can, we'll deliver a very different marketing message for the same product to a group of 45 year olds from Rhode Island than to 35 year olds in Atlanta. And, different demographic groups are drawn to different products - for the most part, the women who regularly read Cosmopolitan are different than those who regularly read Redbook; the men who read Playboy different from those who read Hustler. Since all this applies to marketing to groups, why wouldn't it apply to influencing individuals?

I try to get a "demographic profile" in my mind of the person I'm working with - what are his "vital statistics"? - age, income, marital and family status, home town, educational background, etc. I ask myself: who else do I know who closely matches that demographic profile? What is that person like?

I happen to know a guy very, very well who is the demographic clone of H. Ross Perot. They both got their early entrepreneurial experience delivering newspapers on horseback. Their upbringing - virtually identical. I mean, their backgrounds are virtually interchangeable. As a result, watching Perot-the-candidate come forward has been especially interesting to me. I know what Perot's going to say before he says it. When Marilyn Quayle attacked him on the Today Show, I knew instantly how Perot would react and what he'd say. There's a technical term for this: "demographic overlay." If you can do a demographic overlay, you can quickly read someone's mind.

THE BIGGEST DIFFERENCE: "THINK" VS. "FEEL"

There is a substantial amount of very good, very interesting and very sophisticated literature out there about the importance of communicating differently with men than with women, and you can make a study of all this if you like. But the shorthand, shortcut is that most (not all) males respond primarily on a "thinking" level; most (not all) women respond primarily on a "feeling " level....egs. "how do you feel about that" vs. "what do you think about that?"

If you want to achieve open communication, making this single adjustment and staying on the appropriate think/feel "channel" is very important.

I'd add that women generally, and probably correctly, trust their "intuition," instincts, subconscious mind's opinions, whatever you want to call it, much more than men do. Whether they ever analytically sort it out or not, women seem more tuned into nonverbal communication, to confidence; they've got better built-in truth detectors than men do. (Except when "blinded" in a romantic relationship.)

BE AN INFORMED, INTERESTING PERSON

You have to be able to talk with people about what interests them before you can get them to open up to you.

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If I say to you, "If you die, will you leave your family penniless and in poverty?", you automatically get a picture in your mind. Now that may be a classic, Depression era picture of a woman and a couple urchins, in scruffy clothes, sitting on a doorstep. It might be a gleeful picture of your cheating, bitching, ungrateful wife bursting into tears at the reading of your will. It will be a picture, but I have exerted little control over what the picture will be. I could further suggest the nature of the picture, couldn't I? And that's the "trick" - to deliberately extend the suggestion.

If I say: let's take a week off and go to a beach somewhere, I'm again leaving the picture at risk. You may conjure up a positive, persuasive scene of you on a beach, getting a tan, watching gorgeous girls in skimpy bikinis, etc. - or you may pull up the very memorable picture of your last trip to Mexico, sunburn, stomach virus and all. But if I fully detail my picture, I can make it your picture. If I say: let's take a week off, go to the beach, get a couple hammocks in good positions, a cooler of drinks, some good books, leave the cellular phones locked up at home and really relax...and I know just the place, where there'll be a good breeze, pure white sand, clear water and lots of great looking women...what pictures are you forming in your mind now?

Try this exercise. Find a quiet, comfortable place to sit. Sit down and clear your mind as best you can. Now, think back to the last time you took a good, bracing hot shower - maybe this morning - and concentrate on your fingers and hands, the hot water splashing over them. Switch to starting and building a fire. See yourself rubbing your hands together over that great fire, soaking in the warmth.

It won't be long before your hands actually get warmer. The power of suggestion is so great that most people can raise or lower their entire body temperature or any part of their body by 10 to 15 degrees purely through mental imagery. There is a physiological reaction to a psychological exercise.

Cavett Robert says "people won't buy burial plots unless they see the hearse parked at the door." He oughta know - he made a fortune teaching people how to sell burial insurance. And the key word there is "see." So your job is to speak in a way that conveys the right pictures. Know that everything you say will become pictures - the question is: what pictures?

When I say from the front of the room in my marketing seminars, "Think about what it would be like to get up each and every morning KNOWING, absolutely knowing exactly how many calls you will receive that day, from new prospects ready and eager to do business with you. What would that feel like? How would you like to live that way?"...I'm hoping for some very definite pictures...that the person in the audience sees himself, getting up spryly, eagerly, rather than crawling out of bed; smiling into the mirror; maybe answering the phone and getting a pleasant call from a customer. But whenever time permits, I go ahead and add: "I'll bet you'd get out of bed a little differently than you do some mornings now. I'll bet you'd jump up and say 'Good morning, God!' instead of 'Good God, it's morning.' I'll bet you'd give that mirror a big smile." This is suggestion at work.

Now, any good hypnotist or hypnotherapist will tell you that some people are more "suggestible" than others, so this works differently with different people. And it's rare that anybody gets so

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good at using the power of suggestion that he can literally, totally control another person's responses. But make no mistake about it, everybody has some degree of receptivity to this type of suggestion, and anybody can learn to use this power.

SUMMARY OF KEY STRATEGIES

1. Don't "show off." Let the other person have the spotlight. Subvert your ego.
2. Give lots of Recognition and Appreciation.
3. Show appreciation for the value of the information given to you by the other person.
4. Build the other person up -- ADD to his/her self-esteem.
5. Be a cheerful person.
6. Maintain a healthy sense of humor.
7. Avoid the 'feel' of interrogation.
8. Reveal yourself (to get others to reveal themselves).
9. Learn to creatively structure your questions.
10. Emulate others who ask questions effectively.
11. Have the "learner" attitude.
12. Listen ACTIVELY.
13. Totally concentrate.
14. SHOW your interest.
15. Realize what a great emotional need just about everybody has to be listened to.
16. Be alert for the 'extra messages.'
17. Maintain eye contact.
18. Learn to read body language.
19. Learn to 'speak' body language.
20. Use specific body language to set up and assist special communication situations. (Johnny Carson example.)

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21. Learn to 'mirror.'

22. Present the most effective image.

23. Prepare.

24. Invade the other person's environment and be observant. (Thinking leaves clues.)

25. Look for the chink in the armor.

26. Play the odds. Bet that basic human characteristics are at work.

27. You CAN judge a book by its cover.

28. Consider the person's demographics.

29. Motivate women differently than men and vice versa.

30. Use 'FORM' to discover the person's main area of interest.

31. Know a little about a lot of different things.

32. Think twice about trying to accomplish anything with a person who is clearly irrational.

33. Use the power of suggestion.

ESSENTIAL READING

USE BOTH SIDES OF YOUR BRAIN GETTING THROUGH TO PEOPLE by Jesse Nirenberg/by Tony Buzan/Plume Books Reward Books

SECRETS OF THE AMAZING KRESKIN/Prometheus Books

BODYBUSINESS by Ken Cooper/Published by AmaCom

UNLIMITED POWER by Tony Robbins/Fawcett

TRUE BELIEVER by Eric Hoffer